
The Antecedents of Deinstitutionalization

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Abstract

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Deinstitutionalization refers here to the erosion or discontinuity of an institutionalized organizational activity or practice. This paper identifies a set of organizational and environmental factors that are hypothesized to determine the likelihood that institutionalized organizational behaviours will be vulnerable to erosion or rejection over time. Contrary to the emphasis in institutional theory on the cultural persistence and endurance of institutionalized organizational behaviours, it is suggested that, under a variety of conditions, these behaviours will be highly susceptible to dissipation, rejection or replacement.

Introduction

Institutional theory and research have contributed valuable insights into the causes of institutionalization in organizations and the processes by which organizations acquire social acceptability and endorsement as a consequence of conformity to the norms and expectations of the institutional environment (Meyer and Rowan 1977; Zucker 1977, 1983; DiMaggio and Powell 1983; Meyer, Scott and Deal 1983; Tolbert and Zucker 1983; Scott 1987a). Institutional theorists place particular emphasis on legitimation processes and the tendency for institutionalized organizational structures and procedures to be taken for granted or viewed as legitimate by the organizations that adopt and perpetuate them (Meyer and Rowan 1977; Zucker 1987). Institutionalized organizational behaviours have been defined as stable, repetitive and enduring activities that become 'infus[ed] with value beyond the technical requirements of the task at hand' (Selznick 1957: 17). From an institutional perspective, the force of habit, history and tradition within the organization creates value congruence among organizational members around the propriety of re-enacted activities, causing these activities to acquire a rule-like status that renders them highly resistant to change (Berger and Luckmann 1967; Zucker 1983; Hinings and Greenwood 1988a). External institutional pressures for organizational conformity from the state and society also sustain and perpetuate adherence to legitimated organizational activities (DiMaggio and Powell 1983; Tolbert and Zucker 1983; Scott 1987a; Oliver 1988, 1991; Baum and Oliver 1991).

The emphasis in the institutional literature on legitimation processes, organizational conformity and enduring organizational change has tended to preclude inquiry into the factors that cause organizations to challenge, discard or abandon legitimated or institutionalized organizational practices. In the absence of attention to the conditions under which shared normative understandings and institutionalized acceptance of organizational actions begin to atrophy or fragment, the institutional literature has overlooked the potentially significant role of deinstitutionalization in explaining organizational behaviour and change. Deinstitutionalization is defined here as the process by which the legitimacy of an established or institutionalized organizational practice erodes or discontinues. Specifically, deinstitutionalization refers to the delegitimation of an established organizational practice or procedure as a result of organizational challenges to or the failure of organizations to reproduce previously legitimated or taken-for-granted organizational actions.

The purpose of this paper is to identify the factors that are likely to predict deinstitutionalization. It is suggested here that under certain specific conditions organizational behaviour and change will be explained not by social consensus around the meaning and value of an activity or by conformity to institutional pressures, but by the failure of organizations to accept what was once a shared understanding of legitimate organizational conduct or by a discontinuity in the willingness or ability of organizations to take for granted and continually re-create an institutionalized organizational activity.

An examination of deinstitutionalization and its causes is potentially important for several reasons. First, deinstitutionalization may explain a broad range of changes in organizations that an institutional perspective has traditionally neglected, including challenges to the institutional status quo, the abandonment of habits and customs, and the deterioration of organizational consensus around the value of institutionalized activity. Second, the causes of deinstitutionalization explain when institutional pressures are least likely to exert an enduring influence on organizations. Institutional theorists have tended to emphasize the cultural persistence of institutionalized organizational forms and process (Zucker 1977, 1987; Scott 1987b). The potential for deinstitutionalization of organizational activities calls into question the stability and longevity of institutional values and practices, suggesting instead that under a variety of predictable conditions, institutionalized processes or practices will be vulnerable to challenge, reassessment or rejection. Third, deinstitutionalization describes the conditions under which institutional pressures for conformity and shared interpretations of institutional rules and expectations fail in their predicted effects on organizations. Therefore, an examination of deinstitutionalizing pressures may help to clarify the boundary conditions of institutional explanations and, by doing so, shed light on the conditions or organizational contexts within which institutional explanations might be most relevant or powerful. Finally, institutional theory has been increasingly criticized for its lack of attention to political processes as well

as other non-institutional factors in shaping the responses of organizations to institutional pressures (Perrow 1985; Powell 1985; Covaleski and Dirsmith 1988; DiMaggio 1988; Oliver 1991). This paper incorporates political, economic and social pressures within an institutional framework to explain the factors that precipitate deinstitutionalization.

Background

Institutionalized activities '...are maintained over long periods of time without further justification or elaboration, and are highly resistant to change' (Zucker 1987: 446). The persistence of institutionalized activities is rooted in their taken-for-granted character 'as defining the "way things are" and/or the "way things are to be done"' (Scott 1987a: 496). Institutionalized practices come to be seen by organizational participants as the only natural or 'obvious' way to conduct an activity; resistance of such practices to change is explained by the influence of history and habit in sustaining organizational behaviours and by tendencies for continually reproduced behaviours to be self-reinforcing over time (Tushman and Romanelli 1985; Scott 1987a; Zucker 1987).

Although deinstitutionalization has received little attention in the institutional literature (Zucker 1988), several change theorists have formulated broad explanations of organizational change on the basis of changing interpretive schemes and institutional resistance to fundamental organizational transformations. Hinings and Greenwood (1988a) describe interpretive schemes as values and beliefs that underpin coherent organizational types or configurations. These interpretive schemes play an important role in determining the particular 'tracks' (i.e. movement or inertia) between organizational archetypes. When organizations undergo transformation, 'prevailing ideas and values [lose] legitimacy and become discredited. In their place, an alternative interpretive scheme emerges, carrying with it a different pattern of structural arrangements' (Greenwood and Hinings 1988: 306). Their framework explains the delegitimation and replacement of interpretive schemes in terms of the interaction among contingencies (e.g. environment), power dependencies and members' patterns of commitment to existing or alternative interpretive schemes.

Other studies have also examined changes in interpretive schemes to explain radical transformations of organizational structures. In a case study of a religious order, for example, Bartunek (1984) showed how changes in shared interpretive schemes within the order were linked to restructuring. Barley's (1986, 1990) studies of two radiology departments explained the evolution of restructuring following the introduction of new technology as the dynamic interplay between institutionalized roles and the patterns of actions and interactions among individuals. Interactions were proposed to produce 'slippage ... between the institutional template and the exigencies of daily life' (Barley 1986: 80). In response to

external dictates and disturbances, actions began to modify or replace institutionalized roles and changed patterns of interaction eventually reconfigured the organization's institutional structure (Barley 1986).

Several contingency theorists have also acknowledged that organizations possess inertial qualities that cause resistance to fundamental change (Miller and Friesen 1984; Tushman and Romanelli 1985). As Tushman and Romanelli (1985: 193) observe, 'the process of institutionalization, whereby recruits are rapidly socialized and organizational values and norms are taken for granted, is driven by conformity generating processes throughout the organization'. Although these institutionalized values and beliefs permit more predictability and stability in work settings, they constrain fundamental design change. From a contingency perspective, institutionalized beliefs and interpretive schemes bring coherence to design archetypes, but also impede discontinuous or radical transformation (Tushman and Romanelli 1985; Hinings and Greenwood 1988a).

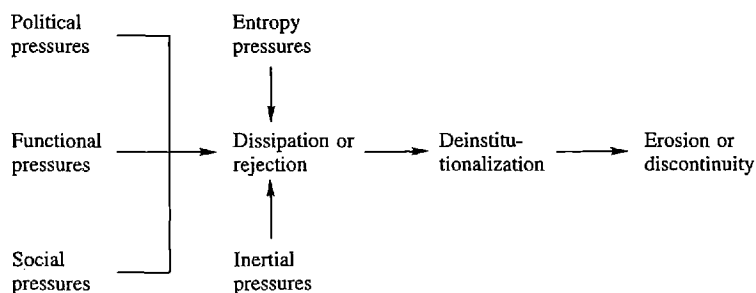
These organizational change theorists have sought to develop broad frameworks for understanding design change as an outcome of many factors, including institutional values and beliefs. Although these frameworks have contributed significantly to our understanding of fundamental transformations, they pay less attention to the antecedents than the consequences of institutional change and tend to focus on the effects of institutional change on organizational structure (Bartunek 1984; Miller and Friesen 1984; Barley 1986). Moreover, studies of design change have identified exogenous factors almost exclusively as precipitating initial change (Bartunek 1984; Barley 1986; Hinings and Greenwood 1988a). None of these frameworks address institutional erosion in detail or attempt to specify the range of determinants of deinstitutionalization, at both organizational and environmental levels of analysis.

Antecedents of Deinstitutionalization

Figure 1 summarizes the predictive and moderating factors that are hypothesized to cause institutionalized organizational practices to fall into disfavour or disuse. Political, functional and social mechanisms both within and beyond the organization are proposed as determinants of deinstitutionalization. Entropy and inertial pressures are proposed as inherent and competing processes in organizations that moderate the rate of deinstitutionalization; organizational entropy tends to accelerate the process of deinstitutionalization, whereas organizational inertia tends to impede it. These five pressures together determine the probability of dissipation or rejection of an institutionalized organizational practice.

Dissipation refers to a gradual deterioration in the acceptance and use of a particular institutionalized practice. An organization, for example, may

Figure 1
Pressures for
Deinstitutionalization



gradually discontinue the enforcement of dress codes in the office or the traditional use of a special standing committee to investigate organizational problems. In these cases, deinstitutionalization or delegitimation of a customary practice is the result of a gradual atrophy in use; previously accepted practices or activities are no longer continually reproduced or re-enacted over time. Rejection is a more direct assault on the validity of a long-standing tradition or established activity. For example, direct challenges to the appropriateness of traditional job classifications on the basis of stereotypical gender roles have led to the deinstitutionalization of this practice in many organizations. Empirical indicators of deinstitutionalization, therefore, include a significant reduction in either the frequency of pervasiveness of an established organizational activity or a discontinuity in its use altogether. Table 1 summarizes the competitive, functional and social pressures within an organization and in an organization's environment that are hypothesized to cause the deinstitutionalization of an established organizational practice.

Table 1
Antecedents of
Deinstitutionalization

Level of Analysis	Political Pressures	Functional Pressures	Social Pressures
Organization	Mounting performance crisis	Changing economic utility	Increasing social fragmentation
	Conflicting internal interests	Increasing technical specificity	Decreasing historical continuity
Environment	Increasing innovation pressures	Increasing competition for resources	Changing institutional rules and values
	Changing external dependencies	Emerging events and data	Increasing structural disaggregation

Political Pressures

Institutionalized practices will be under threat of erosion or displacement when the utility or legitimacy of such practices is seriously called into question. The political conditions under which this delegitimation of organizational practices is predicted to occur include mounting performance crises; a growth in the criticality or representation of organizational members whose interests or beliefs conflict with the status quo; increased pressures on the organization to adopt innovative practices; and a reduction in the dependence on the institutional constituents that have encouraged or enforced continuing procedural conformity with their expectations. The first two mechanisms of deinstitutionalization are intra-organizational factors that erode political agreement on the value or validity of an institutionalized organizational practice. The latter mechanisms are environmental pressures that cause organizations to question the necessity or appropriateness of maintaining a traditional organizational practice in response to specific environmental changes.

Mounting performance problems or crises tend to erode institutionalized organizational activities and create internal political dissensus. Bartunek (1984: 365) describes how the validity of a religious order's institutionalized beliefs and practices were challenged by crisis; 'the "crisis" for the order was occasioned by the Vatican Council's mandate . . . this mandate opened the way for challenge to the order's interpretive schemes'. Problems that threaten the legitimacy or survival of an organization, in particular, cast doubt on the validity of organizational procedures that have traditionally served the organization's interests effectively. When a non-profit agency recognizes that its customary practices for soliciting donations are no longer working or when a producer witnesses the growing market share of a direct competitor who has adopted innovative human resource management policies, the legitimacy of what were once 'tried and true' organizational activities may be seriously questioned or rejected. Performance crises also tend to heighten the potential for internal conflict and to fragment shared interpretations of appropriate organizational behaviour. The *Challenger* disaster, for example, created political dissensus around the possible causes of its occurrence and provoked serious doubts within the organization about a range of long-standing practices and procedures that NASA had established to ensure the safety and success of its missions (Starbuck and Milliken 1988). Therefore, performance problems and crises tend to raise serious questions about the appropriateness or legitimacy of institutionalized organizational procedures and to provide the basis for internal disagreement over which organizational activities need to be abandoned or revised in order to rectify existing organizational problems.

Performance crises and interorganizational conflict may also cause a deterioration in consensus among organizations in the same institutional field or sector. For example, voluntary social service agencies may devi-

ate from institutionally defined norms of inter-agency cooperation when the viability or survival of individual agencies is threatened. During a period of crisis, members of a cartel may abandon consensually defined rules of collective behaviour in favour of self-interested gain and individual protection. Under these conditions, the logic of confidence (Meyer and Rowan 1983) and institutional coherence that have perpetuated institutionalized rules of appropriate conduct begin to break down and destabilize, as shared expectations of acceptable and legitimate activity become supplanted by the pursuit of organizational interests and individual protection. In a study of a university's budgeting process, Covalleski and Dirsmith (1988), for example, adopted an institutional framework to describe how threats to the university's interests and viability, as well as interorganizational conflicts with the state, caused the organization to build political support in protection of its own interests and to reject institutionally prescribed budgeting allocations and practices.

Since consensus or 'reciprocal typifications' among actors on the meaning, value and validity of an organizational form or activity is a fundamental condition of ongoing conformity to institutional practices (Berger and Luckmann 1967; Meyer and Rowan 1977; Scott 1987a), the development of political dissensus or conflicting interests that disrupt the unanimity of agreement among organizational members on the value of a particular practice will be a critical antecedent to deinstitutionalization. Such dissensus, however, does not only emerge out of crises. In some circumstances dissensus arises when specific organizational stake-holders with growing power or visibility no longer possess any interest in sustaining an organizational practice or perceive the practice to conflict with their own interests, agendas or beliefs. An organization with a tradition of moving only financial personnel into senior positions may find its promotional practices challenged when other professional personnel begin to become critical to the organization's operations (Hickson et al. 1971). Similarly, the increasing representation and promotion of women in a traditionally male-dominated organization will tend to deinstitutionalize institutionalized policies and practices that perpetuate stereotypical roles and behaviours.

In other circumstances, consensus on the merits of an institutionalized practice may decline with a rise in power of intra-organizational entrepreneurs who offer unique or visionary solutions to organizational problems and succeed in mobilizing political support for the imposition of alternative organizational values and activities (Zucker 1988). The engineer that develops a novel solution to a persistent organizational problem or the researcher who provides a creative suggestion for improving the organization's competitive advantage may cause previously taken-for-granted activities to be reconsidered or discarded. Similarly, organizational managers recruited to shake up the status quo commonly precipitate the deinstitutionalization of previously accepted activities and strategies (Tushman and Romanelli 1985). These institutional noncon-

formists will be particularly likely to gain the support of organizational power-holders when current performance is inadequate and when there are mounting competitive pressures on the organization to improve its performance or develop innovative processes.

Many institutionalized practices also have their origins in enduring patterns of dependence on specific environmental constituents. Public schools tend to possess a socially standardized set of institutional categories and policies as a consequence of conformity to the expectations of state constituents and collectively developed agreements about what constitutes effective education (Meyer, Scott and Deal 1983). By the same token, the emergence of alternative schools is explained not only by the alternative beliefs and visions of institutional nonconformists who question the legitimacy of institutionalized definitions of effective education, but also by the availability of alternative funding sources in the community and the private sector that limit a school's external dependency on the state. DiMaggio and Powell (1983: 154), for example, have hypothesized that organizational conformity with the institutional environment will be a function of external dependence; these authors argue for 'the greater ability of organizations to resist the demands of organizations on whom they are not dependent'. Salancik's (1979) research on affirmative action practices showed that compliance with the state on the implementation of these practices was explained by the degree of an organization's dependence on the state. Within any organization, the perceived institutional value of an established practice is likely to erode if its continuity has been sustained primarily by the need to conform to the demands or expectations of an institutional constituent and dependency on this constituent subsequently declines or disappears. When a firm in an industry undergoing deregulation becomes less dependent on the social support of government agencies, many traditional practices established to demonstrate or maintain institutional compliance will be discarded. In the same way, when a manufacturer becomes less dependent on a single supplier, the value of institutionalized practices, such as nourishing the supplier linkage, maintaining high inventories or ensuring prompt payment for critical supplies, may be called into question by the organization and subsequently rejected.

To summarize, the deinstitutionalization of an organizational activity or practice may be a political response to changing power distributions (i.e. political dissensus, leader succession, changing dependency patterns or growth in the criticality or representation of members that oppose the status quo) or a protective response to what is perceived by the organization as an imminent threat of failure or obsolescence (i.e. performance problems and crises, the need for organizational entrepreneurs or increasing external pressures to remain competitive or innovative). Deinstitutionalization under these conditions follows from the political efforts of organizations to protect their own interests or viability and to accommodate or resolve political conflict surrounding the value or legitimacy of an institutionalized organizational activity.

Functional Pressures

The potential for innovative pressures and performance problems to deinstitutionalize enduring organizational practices is also related to technical or functional considerations that tend to compromise or raise doubts about the instrumental value of an institutionalized practice. An institutionalized practice is one which is perceived by organizational members to possess intrinsic worth or legitimacy beyond its technical requirements. The perceived worth of an institutional practice, however, is not invulnerable to re-evaluation or reconsideration in technical terms. Deinstitutionalization may be the consequence of changes to the perceived utility or technical instrumentality of these practices, rather than the result of interest mobilization (DiMaggio 1988; Zucker 1988) or redistributions in organizational power. These changes are predicted to occur when institutional constituents in the environment withdraw the rewards associated with sustaining an institutionalized organizational activity; when social and economic criteria of organizational success begin to conflict significantly with one another; and when the organization experiences an increase in its technical specificity or goal clarity. These changes may also be tied to environmental changes, including intensified competition for resources and the emergence of dissonant information or unexpected events in the environment that directly challenge the advisability of sustaining an institutional activity.

An institutionalized activity may discontinue or decay because its perpetuation is no longer rewarding. Rowan's (1982: 261) study showed how local school systems 'respond as actively to the decline of institutional endorsement as they do to its growth. Structures that lose the support of institutional environments are neither adopted nor retained by local school systems.' Organizations often choose to perpetuate institutional activities in anticipation of acquiring or sustaining a variety of specific benefits that are instrumental to success, including organizational legitimacy and prestige (Meyer and Rowan 1977; DiMaggio and Powell 1983; Meyer and Scott 1983), greater ease of access to critical resources (Pfeffer and Salancik 1978; DiMaggio and Powell 1983) and social support and approval (Meyer, Scott and Deal 1983). In a study of institutional pressures on drug abuse treatment units, for example, D'Aunno, Sutton and Price (1991) showed the central role of rewards (such as funds, personnel and materials) controlled by parent institutions in limiting the deinstitutionalization of traditional drug abuse treatment practices. By the same token, the loss or anticipated loss of institutional incentives for procedural compliance with institutional constituents is likely to deinstitutionalize those procedures. If an institutional agency distributing grants no longer gives preferential treatment to those organizational applicants who submit the most detailed grant proposals, that practice will probably be discarded by organizations. Similarly, the loss or retraction of incentives for failure to comply with institutional

requirements will also provoke the deinstitutionalization of an existing practice. If the state no longer confers lucrative subsidies and social endorsement on organizational contractors that maintain discriminatory personnel practices, the wisdom of perpetuating these practices is likely to be reconsidered. Beyond the social or political implications of sustaining discriminatory personnel policies, any institutionalized activities that begin to have significant implications for the economic success of the organization are likely to be re-evaluated. Covalleski and Dirsmith's (1988) study of a university budgeting process, for example, illustrated how significant decreases in state funding to the university caused the university to begin challenging the traditional institutionalized budget formula.

The utility of an institutionalized practice will also be reassessed when economic criteria of efficiency and effectiveness begin to conflict with, or intrude on, institutional definitions of success. Several institutional theorists have argued that institutionalized rules and procedures tend to be incompatible with organizational efficiency and effective task performance (Selznick 1957; Meyer and Rowan 1977; Meyer, Scott and Deal 1983; Zucker 1987). Organizations may begin to question the functional utility of anything from traditional extended lunch hours to the burdens of compliance with elaborate occupational safety guidelines when the potential for these institutionalized practices to compromise effective task performance and efficiency becomes salient and significant. Conflict between social and economic objectives is most likely to lead to the deinstitutionalization of institutional practices when the organization possesses discretion to abandon the activity (e.g. compliance with voluntary rather than mandated product safety guidelines), when the technical specificity of an organization's operations is increasing (e.g. when a firm shifts its goals from research to production), when important environmental constituents reorient their demands on the organization so that the organization is rewarded less for the sustained implementation of institutionally acceptable structures and procedures and more for the technical quality or quantity of its outputs (e.g. external attempts to evaluate the efficiency of a social service programme), and when intensified competition among organizations makes task efficiency and effectiveness more crucial to organizational success.

Anything that acts to increase an organization's technical specificity and reduce the ambiguity of an organization's processes and outputs will provide fertile ground for the deinstitutionalization of organizational studies. Since institutionalization breeds under conditions of goal ambiguity and technical uncertainty (Selznick 1957; Galaskiewicz and Wasserman 1989), greater clarity in organizational objectives or in the causal processes by which organizational goals are achieved will tend to deinstitutionalize prevailing organizational myths, superstitions or beliefs about the appropriate or legitimate means of obtaining organizational ends. When the processes and technologies for achieving goals are unclear and outputs are difficult to assess, organizations depend less on

concrete indicators of successful performance to determine the appropriateness of an organizational practice and rely more on the confidence and good faith of their internal participants (Meyer and Rowan 1977) or on collectively generated understandings and consensual beliefs about the most acceptable structures and procedures for achieving organizational objectives. A school, for example, '... succeeds if everyone agrees that it is a school; it fails if no one believes that it is a school, regardless of its success in instruction' (Meyer, Scott and Deal 1983: 56). Given the ambiguity in education surrounding means-end relations, appropriate definitions of 'effective instruction', and output measures of 'high quality education', schools rely heavily on consensually derived prescriptions of what constitutes effective education and conformity to categorical and institutionalized roles and routines to maintain the faith of external constituents in the quality of its performance (Meyer and Rowan 1983; Meyer, Scott and Deal 1983). When means-end relations in any organization become clearer (e.g. when a firm discovers what product characteristics its consumers value most), when methods for evaluating outcomes become more precise (e.g. an agency is able to substantiate the key indicators of programme effectiveness) or when organizational objectives become more technically specific (e.g. a change in organizational status from public or non-profit to for-profit), then institutionally prescribed activities and modes of operation will tend to be displaced by more technical criteria of organizational effectiveness.

In addition, external assessments of organizational performance based on technical criteria often intrude on institutional definitions of success, whether or not such criteria are warranted. Attempts to penetrate the public sector with private sector approaches to performance measures (Hinings and Greenwood 1988b: 57) and increasing pressures on public and social service agencies to make efficient use of public resources (Scott 1983: 110) will tend to replace normatively constructed definitions of success with organizational efforts to provide technically defined and concrete indicators of effectiveness. Therefore, shifts in external constituent demands from ceremonial conformity with institutionally defined processes to greater accountability in the efficient utilization of internal resources or the technical quality of an organization's outputs, will tend to erode an organization's reliance on institutional definitions of appropriate practice and encourage the organization to replace these practices with more technically precise or efficiency-oriented performance measures.

The dissipation or rejection of institutional performance measures is often initiated by heightened competition for scarce resources or domains. In the public, social service and voluntary sectors, the drive to increase efficiency and provide creditable accounts of how public resources are utilized or distributed has emerged, in part, from increasing competition for scarce funding and resources (Perry and Rainey 1988). Intensified competition for resources or authority also puts pressures on organizations to be innovative and to search for new methods of dis-

tinguishing themselves from their competitors. Therefore, increased competition is likely to discourage perpetuation of the organizational status quo and motivate organizations to challenge or re-evaluate existing strategies and activities.

Finally, dissonant information or unexpected, irrefutable events in the organization's environment often emerge to discredit or challenge the utility of the operating assumptions of organizations. Although these events and data may be idiosyncratic, non-repetitive and unpredictable, their consequences may be profound in terms of deinstitutionalizing existing beliefs and activities. The revelation of evidence that smoking is harmful deinstitutionalizes the practice of unrestricted smoking in the workplace. A stock market crash, or the failure of a seemingly impervious competitor, will cause organizations to re-evaluate their own assumptions and established practices. Idiosyncratic events (such as poisoning an organization's products) and unexpected deviations from taken-for-granted collective norms (the termination of striking airline employees, for example) tend to throw traditionally perpetuated beliefs and taken-for-granted assumptions into disarray. Unexpected new evidence may also destabilize shared understandings and consensual definitions of appropriate conduct across organizations in the same institutional network or field. When it comes to light that an organization, for example, has violated the collective rules of an interorganizational honour system, the potential for this evidence to erode past practices is high. Business transactions traditionally established by a handshake, for example, may be replaced by formalized contracts among members of the network. An isolated and entirely unexpected case of deception may deinstitutionalize reliance on collective trust or professional ethics and provoke the implementation of extensive regulations or monitoring devices.

To summarize, the causes of deinstitutionalization may be less political than functional under several conditions. The functional utility of an institutionalized practice will be re-evaluated when the instrumental rewards for conformity are retracted, when increasing goal clarity, technical specification, demands for efficiency and resource or domain competition render institutional practices increasingly incompatible with economic and technical objectives, and when dissonant events and data destabilize or violate traditional organizational assumptions and principles. Under these conditions, the functional necessity of an institutionalized activity will be seriously questioned and its presumed utility is likely to be challenged or rejected largely on economic grounds rather than for purposes of accommodating changes in power distributions or political interests.

Social Pressures

Thus far it has been argued that an institutionalized organizational practice is most likely to dissipate or discontinue as a result of specific changes

within the organization and in the organization's environment that portend organizational failure or obsolescence, shift existing power distributions or cause organizations to reconsider the instrumentality of sustaining their traditions. The assumption common to all these mechanisms of deinstitutionalization is that members of the organization consciously acknowledge the need to discard institutionalized practices and then act on this recognition. Social pressures that precipitate deinstitutionalization, by comparison, explain many of the conditions under which organizations are neither pro-active agents of deinstitutionalization nor centrally intent on abandoning or rejecting particular institutional traditions. These conditions include increasing normative fragmentation within an organization as a by-product of other organizational changes (increasing workforce diversity, high turnover, for example); disruptions to the organization's historical continuity (such as mergers); changes in state laws or societal expectations that prohibit or discourage the perpetuation of an institutional practice; and structural changes to the organization or the environment within which the organization resides that disaggregate collective norms and values.

Normative fragmentation refers to a loss of cultural consensus or agreement among organizational members on the meanings and interpretations that they attach to ongoing organizational tasks and activities. When an organizational practice is institutionalized, these practices often assume an objective, fact-like or exteriorized character (Zucker 1977) that makes them seemingly invulnerable to scepticism or even conscious recognition among existing organizational members. Organizations, for example, may have certain ways of handling customers, conducting organizational correspondence or coping with employee grievances that are so entrenched in the organization's history or so widely accepted among organizational members as to be taken for granted by the organization that perpetuates them (Zucker 1983; DiMaggio 1988). Disruptions to the historical continuity of organizations and breakdowns in the unanimity of normative agreement on organizational customs will bring exteriorized actions and practices to the attention of organizational participants and exert social pressures on the organization to change its traditions. A number of factors are likely to cause consensual fragmentation or historical disruptions.

High turnover, leader succession and increases in workforce diversity will tend to impede the endurance of organizational traditions and customs. New members with backgrounds and experiences that differ from existing members bring different interpretive frameworks and social definitions of behaviour to the organization that act to diminish consensus and unquestioning adherence to taken-for-granted practices (Tolbert 1988). Institutionalization also requires shared history and time to establish consensually defined understandings (Berger and Luckmann 1967). High turnover rates, particularly at multiple organizational levels, and leader succession create historical discontinuities that act to sever an organization's links with the past and pre-empt reproducibility of activities over

time. Weak socialization mechanisms within the organization also obstruct the transmission of institutionalized behaviours and practices to new members (Tolbert 1988). For institutional activities to be sustained over time, continuing socialization of new organizational entrants is necessary to bring their beliefs and expectations surrounding specific institutional practices into alignment with existing expectations (Schein 1990). These expectations might include, for example, the amount of overtime that employees work, the degree of deference exhibited to superiors or appropriate behaviours and dress codes to be adopted when meeting customers and clients. In the absence of effective socialization, the entrance of new organizational members, particularly those with different backgrounds and cultural expectations, will eventually erode institutionalized norms and activities.

The potential for destabilization of institutional values and practices will also be a function of an organization's temporary and permanent connections with other organizations. Organizational mergers and vertical integration commonly introduce a new culture into the organization that disrupts the historical continuity of its value system and creates social pressures on the organization to revise its established procedures. When two firms with disparate cultures merge, the social value or legitimacy of a variety of traditions and habits in both firms may be called into question (Walter 1985). Temporary strategic alliances, such as joint ventures, can also throw taken-for-granted organizational practices into high relief and cause organizations to question the validity of such practices. North American joint ventures with Japanese and European firms in several industries, for example, have led to the recognition and re-evaluation of several organizational practices surrounding union-management relations and worker participation that are embedded in distinctly North American cultural traditions.

State and societal forces in the organization's environment are among the most critical agents of institutional change (DiMaggio and Powell 1983). State pressures on organizations to conform to public demands and expectations (e.g. occupational safety, pollution control) typically displace or deinstitutionalize previously institutionalized practices (individual responsibility for worker safety or the traditional use of certain production processes) that were once considered appropriate organizational activities in an earlier context. In their study of British local government offices, for example, Hinings and Greenwood (1988a) illustrated how state pressures for an alternative organizational design tended to delegitimize a professional bureaucratic design among many local offices. Tolbert and Zucker (1983) showed how civil service reforms deinstitutionalized a range of traditional practices and procedures among municipal governments, as these reforms became widely accepted and adopted. A broad literature supports the causal force of state jurisdiction and societal pressures in bringing about institutional change (Meyer and Rowan 1977; DiMaggio and Powell 1983; Scott 1983, 1987a; Tolbert and Zucker 1983; Zucker 1987). State and societal pressures for isomorphic

change and conformity are powerful forces not only for institutionalization but also for the deinstitutionalization of prior organizational traditions and customs.

Finally, the deinstitutionalization of an established organizational practice may be neither state-driven, normatively encouraged, politically motivated nor functionally based. Deinstitutionalization may result from changes to the structure and patterns of interaction within an organization or in an organization's field. These disaggregating changes, which include diversification, geographic dispersion and parochial differentiation, apply to deinstitutionalizing changes both within and across organizations that occupy the same institutional field.

Shared definitions of social reality and common understandings about what is acceptable and meaningful behaviour are often dependent on the physical proximity of institutional constituents to one another and the opportunities for the construction of a common reality through social interaction, imitation and observation (Berger and Luckmann 1967; DiMaggio and Powell 1983; Zucker 1983; DiMaggio 1988). Institutionalized norms and practices are more likely to atrophy or erode when organizational constituents become more geographically dispersed, non-interacting or autonomous. High structural differentiation obstructs interaction and the development of shared perceptions (Lawrence and Lorsch 1967). Geographic differentiation may also obstruct the perpetuation of institutional consensus. A local arts association, for example, may be constituted by members who initially develop common philosophies and procedures that are highly institutionalized through repeated opportunities for interaction and imitation. As the operation of the association becomes more geographically dispersed through national or international expansion, the traditions and institutionalized practices of the association that were established when its members were geographically concentrated may begin to erode, destabilize or come to be replaced with new institutional norms and activities that are more general or defocalized. Organizations that diversify their operations into other sectors or markets, particularly in different countries, are likely to be exposed to alternative organizational customs and, indeed, organizational members may be selected to oversee these operations for their ability to discard ethnocentric institutional assumptions in response to local customs and traditions. A lack of proximity between institutions that enforce conformity and the organizations that are subjected to these pressures may also threaten the endurance of institutionalized practices. The findings of D'Aunno, Sutton and Price's (1991) study of mental health organizations, for example, suggested that the proximity of an institution to the units it monitored may have affected the institution's ability to induce and perpetuate conformity to institutional practices.

Where local demands and interests differ in a geographically dispersed institutional environment, each locale may also replace broadly defined institutional prescriptions of acceptable form or behaviour with different

parochial interpretations of an institutional requirement. In this way, domestic organizations operating in foreign countries impose different interpretations on institutional requirements for ethical organizational behaviour or appropriate employment practices. Similarly, school districts frequently adapt education requirements articulated at the state and national level to fit local needs and issues.

Across organizations, geographical dispersion and parochial differentiation disaggregate institutional environments and reduce the likelihood that organizations will reproduce specific shared interpretations of reality through observation, imitation and network interaction. Several theorists and researchers have noted that network interrelationships can facilitate the maintenance, imitation and diffusion of institutional norms and values (Meyer and Rowan 1977; DiMaggio and Powell 1983; Oliver 1988, 1990; Galaskiewicz and Wasserman 1989). Therefore, when the structure of an institutional field becomes more physically dispersed, loosely connected, non-interactive or locally differentiated, deinstitutionalization of collective values and practices is more likely to occur. Indicators of increasing field disaggregation might include a significant reduction in trade association membership, or declining numbers of board interlocks, inter-agency referrals, interorganizational alliances, joint ventures or joint programmes among organizations in the same industry or sector.

To summarize, social pressures for change often deinstitutionalize established activities in the absence of an organization's conscious recognition or control of these changes or in spite of contrary organizational intentions to sustain the status quo. First, social fragmentation and historical discontinuities cause deinstitutionalization. These deinstitutionalizing predictors include high turnover, succession, increases in workforce diversity, weakening socialization mechanisms and culturally disparate interorganizational relations (mergers, joint ventures, for example). Second, external social pressures, including changes in government laws and societal values or expectations, can cause organizations to abandon or relinquish institutional practices. Finally, structural disaggregation induces deinstitutionalization by reducing the proximity of opportunities for interaction among organizations or their members. Predictors of disaggregation include structural differentiation, diversification and geographic dispersion.

Empirical Predictors of Deinstitutionalization

The foregoing discussion identifies a range of specific empirical predictors of deinstitutionalization. Intra-organizational determinants incorporate three broad types of change: changes in political distributions supporting an established practice, changes in the functional necessity or perceived utility of an established practice and changes in the social consensus surrounding the legitimacy of an established practice. The predictive

factors associated with each type of change are summarized in Table 2. This table also outlines the factors external to the organization that are hypothesized to determine the likelihood of deinstitutionalization. These factors include competitive environment pressures, social environment pressures, dissonant environmental occurrences and changes in the relations of organizations to external constituents.

Table 2
Empirical
Predictors of
Deinstitutionalization

Intraorganizational Factors	Organization-Environment Relations
Changes in political distributions Increasing workforce diversity Declining performance or crises Power reallocations Threat of obsolescence	Competitive environment pressures Increasing resource or domain competition Increasing innovation pressures
Changes in functional necessity Increasing technical specification Increasing goal clarity	Social environment pressures Changing government regulations Changing societal values
Changes in social consensus Increasing turnover or succession Weakening socialization mechanisms Culturally disparate mergers and alliances Increasing diversification, dispersion, or differentiation	Random external occurrences Dissonant events and data Changes in constituent relations Declining external dependence Withdrawal of incentives Rising efficiency standards

Several of these predictive factors are also likely to interact with one another to increase the probability of deinstitutionalization when competitive pressures in the organization's environment are increasing. The threat of obsolescence will be more likely to cause organizations to question existing practices when external innovative pressures are rising. Increasing workforce diversity and organizational turnover rates will tend to be stronger predictors of deinstitutionalization when socialization mechanisms are weak. Finally, an external constituent's withdrawal of rewards or incentives for sustaining an organizational practice is more likely to cause deinstitutionalization when an organization's dependence on that constituent remains high.

Moderating Factors

As Table 2 summarizes, a number of internal and external factors have been proposed as critical determinants of deinstitutionalization. Two inherent properties of organizations may also accelerate or slacken the rate at which deinstitutionalization occurs. Theorists have proposed that organizations possess both inertial qualities (Tushman and Romanelli 1985) and tendencies towards entropy (Zucker 1988). These are expected

to exert opposing forces on the organization in moderating the pace or velocity of deinstitutionalization.

Zucker (1988: 26) has proposed that entropy rather than stability characterizes social systems; organizations in general are typified as tending towards disorganization or a 'gradual erosion of the[ir] taken-for-granted character'. For example, 'all formal roles are continually eroded by the personal characteristics of the current incumbent . . . shaped by the process not simply of role taking but also role making in which the formal attributes of the role are modified' (Zucker 1988: 26). Through inevitable modifications to existing roles and routines, 'institutional rules . . . contain the seeds of their own disruption . . . the end result is that entropy characterizes all but the most highly institutionalized social elements' (Zucker 1988: 26). Tendencies towards entropy are not inconsistent with the potential for random error and chance to disrupt and destabilize institutional systems (Cohen, March and Olsen 1972).

Whereas organizational entropy suggests natural tendencies towards erosion or decay of institutional phenomena, the notion of inertia suggests that institutionalized values and activities will exhibit inevitable resistance to erosion or change. Several theorists have proposed that organizations may tend towards structural inertia and maintenance of the organizational status quo (Hannan and Freeman 1977, 1984, 1989; Miller and Friesen 1984; Tushman and Romanelli 1985; Hinings and Greenwood 1988a). These theorists call attention, in particular, to investments in fixed assets (Hannan and Freeman 1977), internal coordination requirements (Miller and Friesen 1984) and the desire for predictability (Tushman and Romanelli 1985) as forces for resistance to change. Two other factors also contribute to organizational inertia and resistance to abandoning established activities. First, individuals may possess preferences or norms for consistency in their actions over time, based on the perception that continuous commitment to the same activities denotes steadfast purpose or reduces uncertainty (Pfeffer and Salancik 1978; Staw 1981). Second, organizational members that, in fact, recognize the need to discard or relinquish an established practice may be immobilized by the perception, accurate or otherwise, that deinstitutionalization will be costly, or by a lack of expertise or understanding in terms of how deinstitutionalization is to be achieved (Hinings and Greenwood 1988a). An organization, for example, may delay relinquishing traditional filing and bookkeeping practices because it lacks the expertise or knowledge to convert to computerized methods and perceives this conversion to be potentially expensive. Any of these inertial tendencies may reduce the rate at which deinstitutionalization might otherwise occur.

Inertia and entropy, as inherent properties in organizations, are therefore expected to moderate the rate at which institutionalized practices erode over time. Although these properties are not causally central in predicting the likelihood of deinstitutionalization, it is suggested here that the pace of deinstitutionalization may be partially determined by the prevalence of these properties in organizations and that these properties

may account for differences across organizations in the timing of deinstitutionalization and the protractedness of the process.

Implications for Future Research

Institutionalized organizational actions are intrinsically valued, taken for granted and 'rule-like' patterns of organizational behaviour that emerge from conformity to shared definitions of social reality and consensus among organizational actors on the meaning and legitimacy of particular activities and practices (Meyer and Rowan 1977). Among the most significant consequences that institutional theorists attribute to the institutionalization of an organizational activity is relative permanency; once organizational activities are institutionalized, they are assumed to become relatively stable, enduring, reproducible and sustainable over long periods of time without continuing justification (Zucker 1987).

This paper suggests that the cultural persistence of an institutionalized activity may be much more fragile and less inevitable than institutional theory suggests. Under a variety of specified conditions, the meaning or legitimacy of a highly institutionalized organizational activity may be vulnerable to scepticism and re-evaluation, causing the organizational activity to fall into disfavour. It has also been suggested that deinstitutionalization may be a pro-active and conscious response by organizations to changing internal and external events, or the result of changes in the organization and the environment over which organizations exert little discretion or control and to which organizations respond passively or even unconsciously. This paper also distinguishes between externally and internally induced deinstitutionalizing factors. An important starting point for future research on deinstitutionalization in organizations is to distinguish between factors over which organizations exercise strategic choice (e.g. reallocating internal power) and those which are either largely environmentally determined (e.g. enforceable changes to government regulations) or beyond the conscious recognition of the organizational actors on whom they impinge (e.g. subtle changes in social consensus as a result of increasing turnover).

This paper has also proposed that threats to the persistence of an institutionalized practice may be explained by a decline in (a) the functional necessity of the practice, (b) the political interests and agendas that support its maintenance, (c) the degree of cultural consensus among actors that perpetuate it or (d) the structural integrity of proximity and interaction patterns that are necessary to sustain institutional coherence. An important line of future enquiry pertains to the degree of dissensus or lack of unanimity on the value of an activity that is sufficient to destabilize institutional norms and activities. If institutionalized activities are behaviours that reflect 'common understandings' of legitimate behaviour (Zucker 1977), as institutional theorists suggest, then what degree of

consensus is enough to sustain an institutionalized practice? Future research linking deinstitutionalization to concepts of culture as 'shared meaning, shared understanding and shared sense-making' (Morgan 1986: 128) may shed light on the degree of consensus necessary to prevent the erosion of institutionalized practices (Smircich 1983; Meek 1988; Schein 1990). Since organizations often possess 'competing value systems that create a mosaic of organizational realities rather than a uniform corporate culture' (Morgan 1986: 127), studies incorporating a political-cultural analysis of institutionalized activities (Lucas 1987) may help to determine how dissensus creates institutional adjustments or erosion, and how negotiation processes may create consensual perceptions. As Lucas (1987) notes, 'negotiation processes occurring continuously between groups create typified rules which become reified by those who use them'. Future research should also take account of organizational mechanisms which attempt to contain or localize institutional opposition, such as loose coupling, employee terminations and cooptation processes (Pfeffer and Salancik 1978; Weick 1979). Given the tendency for institutional theorists to define institutionalized phenomena as 'fully reciprocated typifications' (Berger and Luckmann 1967; Meyer and Rowan 1977), even limited opposition to predominantly legitimated organizational activities, particularly from institutional nonconformists with the vision and political power to impose alternative solutions to organizational problems, may be largely sufficient to destabilize institutionalized activities and practices.

Institutional theorists have described how institutional processes emerge from the collective social construction of reality (Scott 1987a). This paper suggests that an understanding of institutionalization also depends on an investigation of the processes by which organizations reconstruct reality when existing values and practices are rejected or invalidated. Therefore, future researchers might explore how delegitimation fosters institutional replacement. When an institutionalized norm or activity that has been consensually accepted breaks down or disintegrates, the institutional void that this process creates may precipitate institution-building initiatives undertaken to repair institutional disenchantment, replace the loss of an institutional procedure or restore the logic of confidence that has been called into question by the fall from grace of a cherished value or tradition. Moreover, when institutionalized practices are suddenly invalidated in response to the emergence of dissonant information or events (e.g. unexpected violations of trust, breaches of security, product tampering), organizations may allocate disproportionately large amounts of time and resources to rebuilding institutional confidence. A single employee theft may lead to the installation of elaborate security systems; an isolated case of fraud may generate the introduction of extensive rules and regulations; an industrial accident unlikely to reoccur may none the less lead to dramatic changes in the law or to the commitment of vast resources to ensure that the problem or offence is never repeated. These activities

constitute vigorous institution-building efforts intended to reaffirm normative coherence, to legitimate and restabilize subsequent norms and practices, and to convince the responding organization and others that the damages of deinstitutionalization are not irreparable. Therefore, future research should focus on the outcomes of deinstitutionalization, particularly in terms of disrupting organizational confidence and precipitating the genesis of new institutional rules or practices. Deinstitutionalization may be an important precondition for the development of new institutional initiatives intended to fill the normative and procedural vacuum that institutional displacement and delegitimation creates. From this perspective, deinstitutionalization may help to predict or explain how new organizational institutions are created and sustained.

Further enquiry into the process of deinstitutionalization is also substantiated by the relatively profound stress that may be associated with these processes, particularly when institutionalized practices are challenged and rejected relatively rapidly rather than subjected to gradual dissipation over time. As prized traditions are revealed to be illegitimate or dysfunctional, and normatively endorsed activities that have served the organization's interests are recognized as invalid blueprints for future organizational action, organizations may experience a loss of coherence, identity, sense of competence or security (Schein 1990). Studies of the relationship between deinstitutionalization and organizational members' stress may shed light on the coping behaviours that individuals adopt in response to institutional disruptions, and may help to explain the tenacity of members' commitments to tenuous or declining institutional activities.

Changes in patterns of organizational power, authority and political influence may also be inevitable outcomes of institutional rejection. The deinstitutionalization of an activity may elevate the political status of those who opposed the activity and compromise the political influence of organizational members who were the strongest advocates of its perpetuation. Where an alternative organizational activity is proposed as a replacement for rejected organizational traditions, proponents of the new institutional order will be intent on mobilizing political support for its acceptance and implementation, and control may be redistributed to those with the legitimacy, power, competence or bargaining skills to convince others of its validity. The political fallout of deinstitutionalization, as well as the regenerative processes by which organizations rectify the disenchantment and uncertainty that delegitimation precipitates, warrant attention in future theory and research.

Finally, this paper proposes that political processes and economic considerations should be incorporated into institutional explanations of organizational activities in order to specify more precisely the particular situations or conditions within which institutionalized activities are most likely to persist or endure. Several institutional theorists have recently acknowledged the role of political processes in explaining institutional change (Covalesski and Dirsmith 1988; DiMaggio 1988; Oliver 1991).

Longitudinal studies of institutionalized organizational activities under conditions of declining performance, intensified resource competition or increasing pressures on the organization to rationalize its activities or account for the efficient utilization of its resources, would provide particularly appropriate contexts within which to examine the contribution of political and economic factors to the destabilization of institutional practices.

Conclusion

This paper has proposed that the persistence and longevity of institutionalized values and activities may be less common than the emphasis of institutional theory on cultural persistence and the diffusion of enduring change implies (Zucker 1977, 1983; Tolbert and Zucker 1983). Theorists have observed that institutionalized organizational habits and traditions exhibit generalized tendencies towards entropy and erosion or, alternatively, inertia and stability (Hannan and Freeman 1977, 1984; Zucker 1988). In contrast, this paper argues that our understanding of institutional erosion or stability can be most constructively advanced by attempting to specify with some precision the particular predictive factors and conditions that make erosion most probable. To this end, ten organizational factors and eight external factors were hypothesized to be causally central in predicting the likelihood that an institutionalized organizational practice will erode or discontinue. Most empirical work from an institutional perspective has focused exclusively on exogenous sources of institutional conformity and change (Zucker 1988). There has been limited theorizing and no empirical research on the antecedents of deinstitutionalization.

Although a number of factors have been identified as critical determinants of deinstitutionalization, it is anticipated that particular factors will exhibit primacy in determining the likelihood that institutionalized practices will discontinue. Among the external pressures identified, changing government regulations are most likely to deinstitutionalize past practices, given the strength of coercion that underpins the legal enforcement of government mandates (DiMaggio and Powell 1983; Scott 1987a; Oliver 1991) and the magnitude of sanctions that may be imposed on an organization for failure to abandon traditional practices in response to changing legal requirements. In this way, legal and regulatory authority may interact with several other external factors, noted earlier, to further increase the probability of deinstitutionalization. For example, when changing societal values become represented by the state, or when rising efficiency standards are imposed by government mandate, the potential for deinstitutionalization of historically entrenched practices and standards will be extremely high.

Among the internal forces for deinstitutionalization identified, performance problems and crises are expected to predominate in predicting deinstitutionalization.

stitutionalization. This is consistent with previous work on organizational learning and 'unlearning' which suggests that organizational unlearning is typically problem-triggered, and that organizational success reinforces the current practices of organizations, obstructing their ability to discard obsolete or misleading knowledge, even in the face of strong disconfirmations (Argyris and Schön 1978; Hedberg 1980). Particularly when problems or crises are perceived by organizational members to jeopardize organizational survival, the risks associated with sustaining the status quo will tend to be viewed as more considerable than the risks to stability and security associated with deinstitutionalization. Severe performance problems and crises commonly precede or exacerbate other identified changes that provoke deinstitutionalization as well, including conflicting interests (Pfeffer and Salancik 1978), power reallocations (Covalesski and Dirmsmith 1988), executive succession (Tushman and Romanelli 1985) and weakening socialization mechanisms (Tolbert 1988). Therefore, performance problems and crises may interact with other intra-organizational determinants to intensify the probability of deinstitutionalization.

This paper is the first to examine the conditions under which presumably persistent institutionalized activities are likely to erode, destabilize or disappear. Although institutionalized organizational behaviours are defined as those that endure for reasons other than efficiency or technical utility, it is not the case that their social legitimacy or fact-like status necessarily insulates them from rejection or dissipation for technical or efficiency-related reasons. Nor are institutionalized activities invulnerable to political processes that disrupt the institutional status quo, despite the limited attention that institutional theory has devoted to political influence and interest mobilization in explaining institutional conformity and change (DiMaggio 1988). An examination of the antecedents of deinstitutionalization highlights the causal potency of political and functional processes in shaping organizational behaviour and reinforces the potential for an institutional framework to accommodate these processes in future theory and research on institutional conformity and change.

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